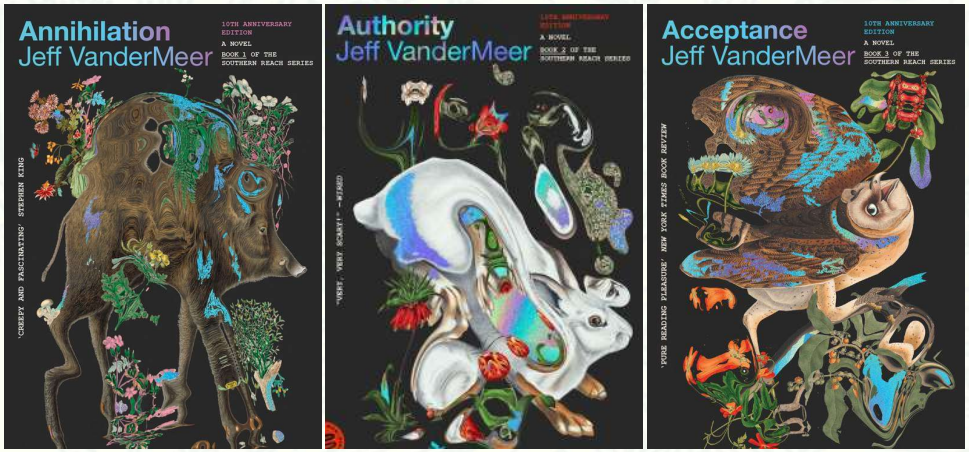
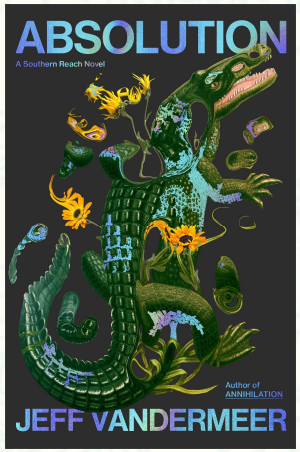
A Reimagined Light: Nature, Post-Human Urbanism, and the Subversion of the American Dream in Jeff VanderMeer's Southern Reach Series

Jacob Moose

Southern Reach Series



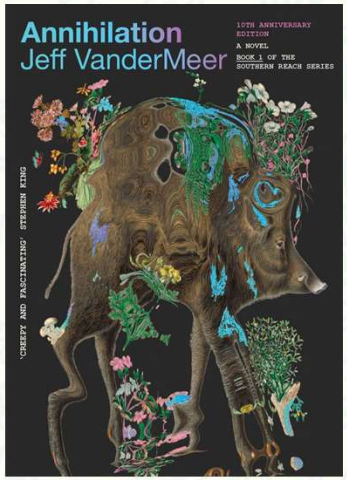


Annihilation ***Authority*** ***Acceptance*** ***Absolution***

- “New Weird” Literature
- Original trilogy published in 2014 ; prequel published in 2024
- Eco-fiction ; largely inspired after Deepwater Horizon Oil Spill in 2010

Southern Reach Series

Annihilation

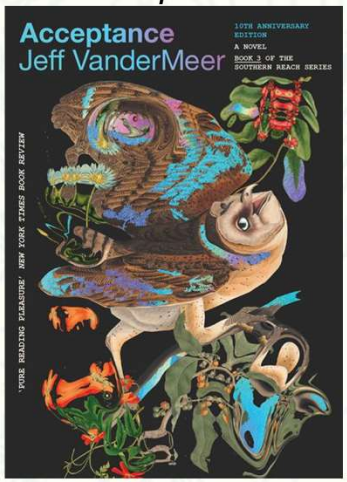


- A team of four women venture into Area X, a space where reality unravels amid strange phenomena

Authority

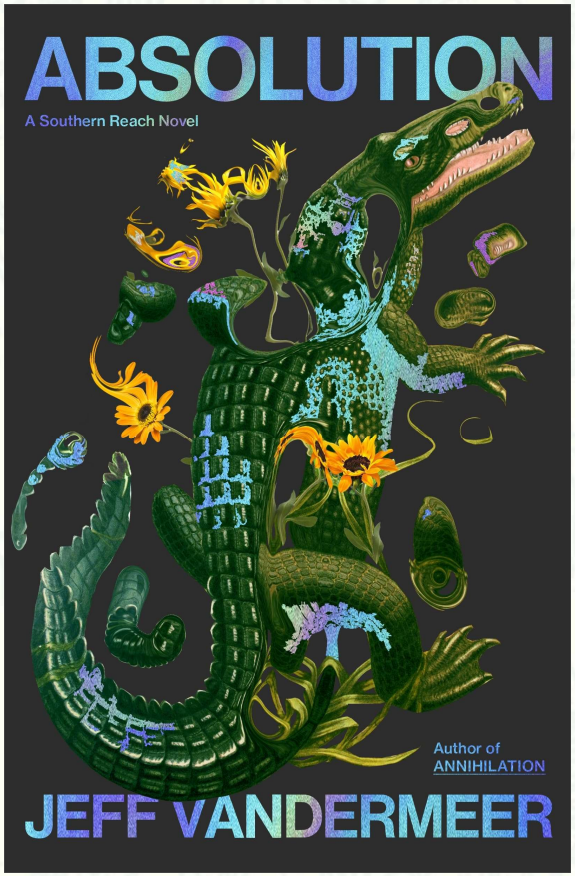
- John “Control” Rodriguez looks closer at the Southern Reach, the secret government agency watching over Area X

Acceptance



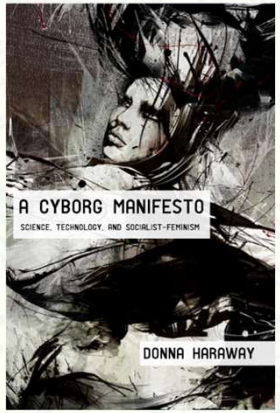
- Characters from past and present confront the truth about Area X as its influence continues to spread beyond its border

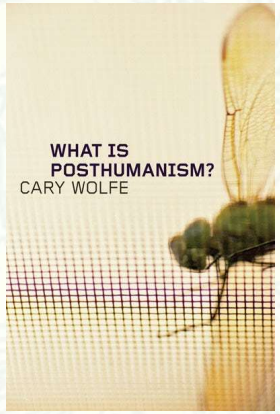
Southern Reach Series

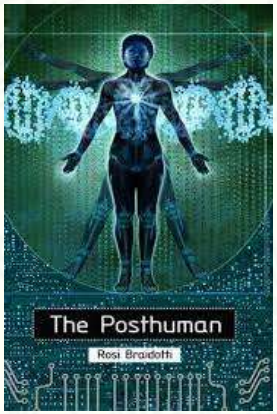


- A prequel to *Annihilation* that explores the birth of Area X and the first expedition
- Follows the scientists, agents, and locals whose actions help lay the groundwork for the Southern Reach
- Novel plays with Time to question whether Area X is an inevitability or something that was (and perhaps still is) preventable

Posthumanist Framework



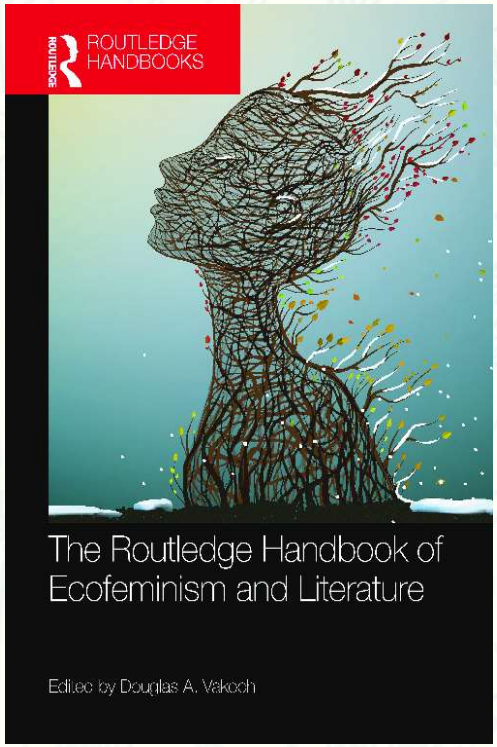




Chief Tenets

- Decentering the Human
- Critique of Humanism
- Blurring Binaries
- Agency of Environment, More-than-Human Life, and Technology

Blurring Binaries



- Human / Nonhuman
- Nature / Culture
- Subject / Object
- Organic / Technological
- Self / Other

Blurring Binaries in Southern Reach Series

Mourning the Human?
Posthuman Death and Ontological Vulnerability in Jeff VanderMeer's The Southern Reach Trilogy

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University of Zaragoza (Spain)

"I Am Not Returning Home": A Transgender Reading of Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation*

Jackson Jesse Nash
School of Media, University of Brighton, Brighton, UK

Monolithic, Invisible Walls:
The Horror of Borders in Jeff VanderMeer's *Southern Reach* Trilogy

Pearson Bolt
University of Central Florida

Second Skins: A Body-Ecology of Jeff VanderMeer's *The Southern Reach Trilogy*[1]

Alison Sperling
University of Wisconsin—Milwaukee

- "Human" / "Nonhuman" Ontological Binaries
- "Natural" / "Unnatural" Body Binaries
- "Us" / "Them" Geographic Binaries
- "Abled" / "Disabled" Body Binaries

Different Approach: Reading Subverted Binaries

- Instead of reading instances where traditional binaries are blurred, can we look at certain instances where they are subverted?
- Reversal of roles as powerful way to question established hierarchies/patterns of thought
- Similar goals to posthumanist framework in that it helps:
  - imagine new ways of being / becoming (the "future of Anthropos")
  - draw attention to the fragility of the human/nonhuman boundary

Tie to the American Dream?

- American Dream reliant upon its own binaries, including:
  - Civilization/Primitivity
  - Nature/Culture
  - Self/Other
- How does Southern Reach Series subvert these binaries?
- Explicit allusion to this subversion through “green light” of Area X?

Manifest Destiny and the American Dream

- Framing of America as a land limitlessly and freely exploitable
- “Conquering” land and "taming" wilderness
- National and personal expansion
- Myth of unlimited land and resources

The American Dream Post-WWII

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Environmental Communication

ISSN: 1752-4032 (Print) 1752-4040 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/renc20

The American Dream: Technology, Tourism, and the Transformation of Wilderness

Tracy Marafiote

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- Post-WWII: prosperity, technology, consumerism equals success
- Nonhuman world viewed as a resource or backdrop to be consumed (or conquered) in the pursuit of this dream
- Tourism transforms “Wilderness” into a commodity: packaged, managed, and made "safe” with the help of technology
- Naturalizes domination and reinforces the American Dream as a narrative of mastery

Area X as Colonizer (Civilization/Primitivity)

- Subversion: Area X seen as primitivity by human characters ("pristine") … but takes on traditional role of civilization ("colonizer")

- In becoming a "colonizer," Area X subverts "colonization" and "civilization"

> "To biologists, a 'colony' occurs when two or more individuals live in close association with—and are often connected to—one another. This ecological basis for understanding 'colonization' is integral to understanding the duality of this term that VanderMeer employs throughout the text, an essential dialectic that mediates not only the characters' experiences but also the story's sociopolitical implications." (Bolt, 26)

- For humans, the "civilizing" / "colonizing" role of Area X is detrimental. For more-than-human-life, it is rooted in diversity, community, and borderless governance

Area X as Urbanist (Nature/Culture)

- Subversion: Area X becomes more like traditional role of Culture in building itself up ; does not need external agent to be “tamed”, “transformed”, or “developed”

- Area X as a kind of urban planner that creates structures (the tower/tunnel in *Annihilation*) and self-sustaining, interconnected ecosystems

- New urban models?
  - No clear line between wildness and design
  - New (human) subjectivities available when perceptions of built environment expand… Southern Reach Series as novels that invite this expansion

- *Posthuman Urbanism* (Shaw, 2017)… asking similar question, but with technology in mind

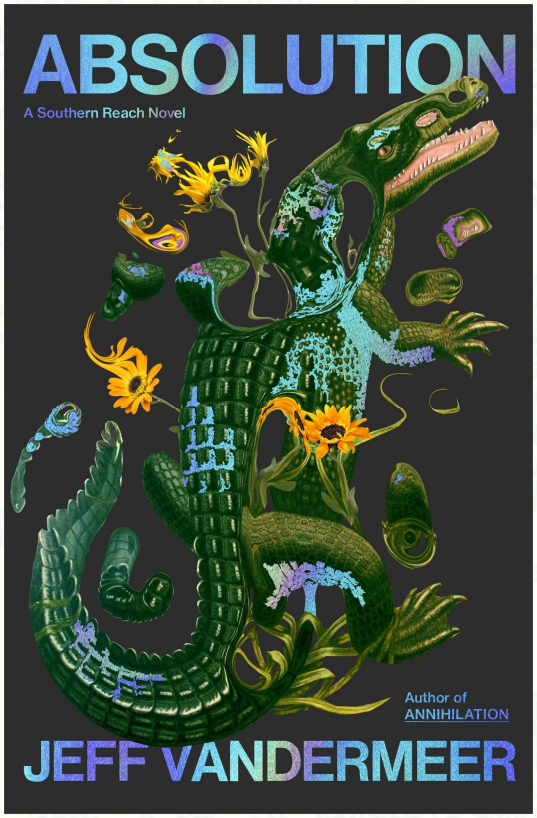
Area X as the Anti-American, American Dream (Self/Other)

- Subversion: American Dream founded upon strong emphasis on individual identity and self-determination ; we see dissolution of the self through Area X (“Human” as Other)
- Characters experience surrender and transformation, showcasing Area X’s alternative “Dream”
- The “Anti-American, American Dream” defined by ecological interdependence and loss of traditional understanding of self can be understood as progress rather than failure
- Difficult process that can be painful (Biologist’s refusal to give into Area X)

A Reimagined Light: The Green Light of Area X

- Green Light as force behind Area X:
  - "On the horizon, the lighthouse had become **a pillar of electric green** spilling a fuzzy rapturous light between fissures of rain." (*Absolution*, 59)
  - "It had stopped raining. He [Control] could see down to the river, to a horizon that held, somewhere, the Southern Reach. Everything was quiet and still, **but there were vague coronas of green light, or purple light, that shouldn't be there**. A vision of whatever was in Area X spilling out over the land, spreading out across the river to Hedley." (*Authority,* 302)
  - "**A brilliant gold-green light erupted from the globe** and plunged into the heart of her [Ghost Bird] and an icy calm came over her, and through the calm bled a kind of monumental light and in that light she could see all that could be revealed even as Area X peered in at her." (*Acceptance*, 286)

A Reimagined Light: The Green Light of Area X



- Biologists' Dream:
  - "A weird **green-gold light** came from the horizon, framed by the cleft between two mountains. An army of scientists and psychics struggled across a plain of sand and bones toward the light. Grim-looking men and women, who looked like veterans of some longer conflict. […] the army fed itself into the cleft between the ridges, ever advancing, ever disappearing into the distance." (*Absolution*, 63)

A Reimagined Light: The Green Light of Area X

- Allusion to the green light in *The Great Gatsby*?
- Subversion of American Dream:
  - Inevitability over Possibility (Area X is happening)
  - Collectivism over Individuality (dissolution of the self)
  - *Zoe* over *Bios* (Braidotti)

Conclusion: Dystopia?

Thank You

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